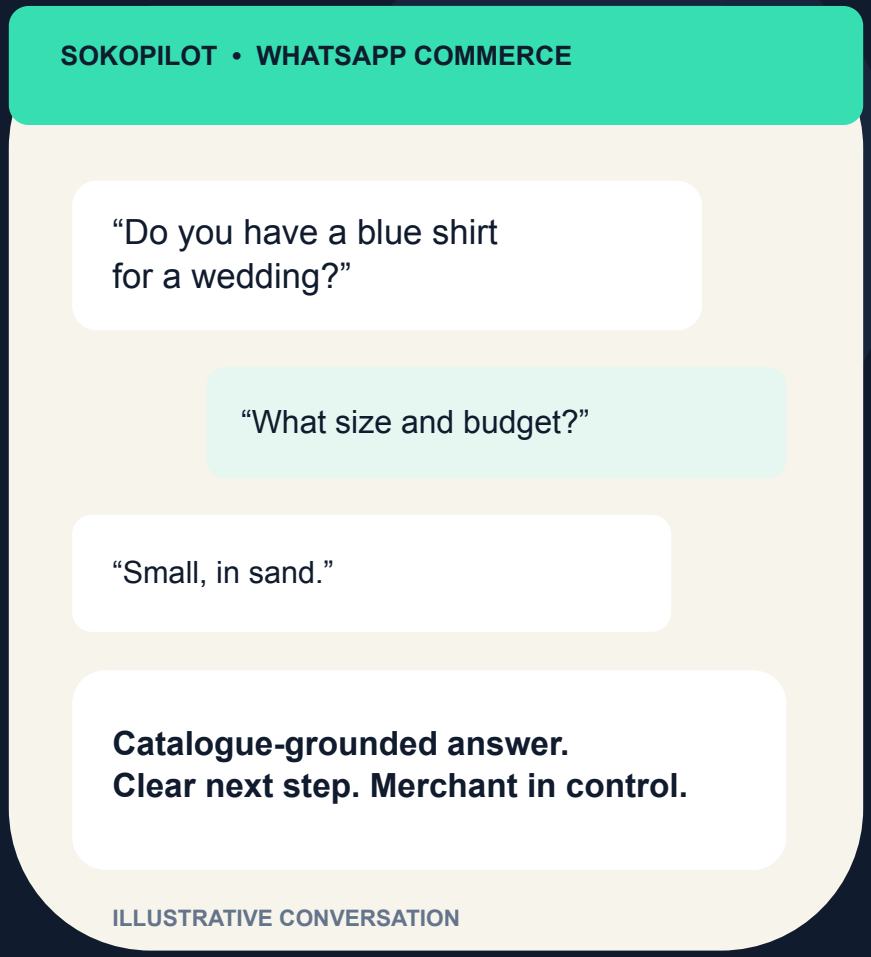
META AI DEVELOPER HACKATHON / STARTUP TRACK

THE STOREFRONT MOVED INTO THE CHAT.

SokoPilot helps small shops serve customers on **WhatsApp** — built for the small businesses powering African markets.

AFRICA-FIRST • HUMAN-LED

The WhatsApp sales copilot for small merchants



Ask → clarify → recommend → hand off

In Kenya, commerce already has a digital front door.

27.4M

internet users in Kenya (January 2025) [1]

WhatsApp 19.8% • Facebook 18.2% [3]

FAMILIAR CUSTOMER CHANNEL

WhatsApp is widely used in Kenya; and in the case of commerce, delayed responses and repetitive tasks within the customer conversion journey leads to friction and drop-offs

THE HIGH-FREQUENCY COMMERCE MOMENTS

01	“Is it in stock?”	AVAILABILITY
02	“Which size fits?”	VARIANT & FIT
03	“What’s the price?”	PRICE & BUDGET
04	“Can you reserve it?”	ORDER INTENT
05	“Where is my order?”	AFTER-SALE SUPPORT

AI chat isn’t the product. A better next step in a buying conversation is.

[1] DataReportal 2025: Kenya (connectivity). [3] Media Council of Kenya 2025: social/digital platform use, not commerce conversion.

The next storefront is conversational

The world is moving towards commerce and sales happening right inside support inside conversations in natural language

SELL WHERE YOUR CUSTOMERS ARE

Meet your customers where they already spend their time, deliver personalized product recommendations and convert

DISCOVERY

What should I buy?

DECISION

Can I trust this answer?

It's the perfect opportunity for small / midsize businesses to close the digital divide

A WhatsApp sales assistant built around merchant control.

Meet customers on a familiar channel. Ground answers in the catalogue. Test before activation.

01

CONNECT

WABA setup target
4 steps • ~2 min

→

02

GROUND

Merchant catalogue
+ current facts

→

03

ASSIST

Clarify • recommend
answer • look up

→

04

CONTROL

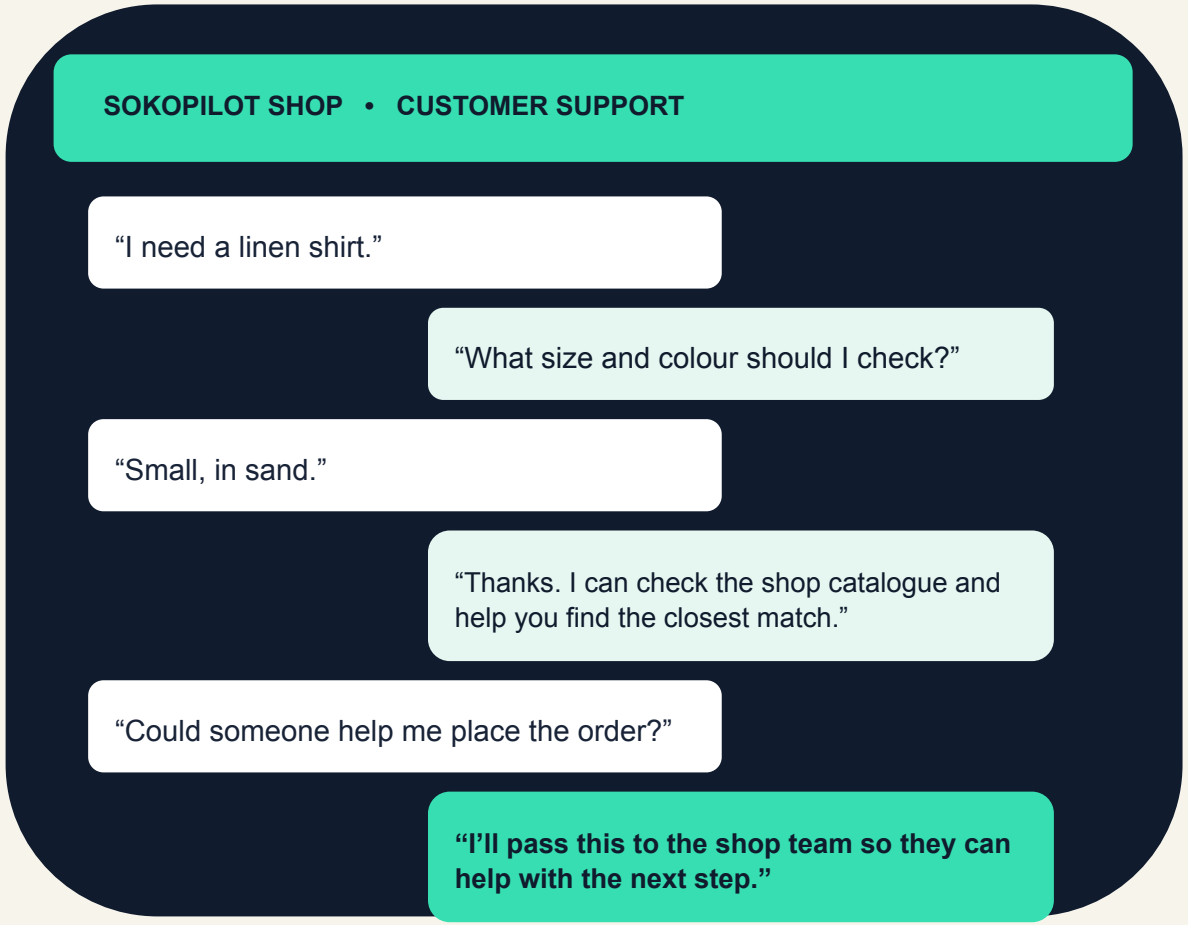
Guide • pause
hand off to human

REAL-WORLD USE

A boutique answers “does this come in medium?”; a grocer checks availability; a repair shop clarifies a service request. The assistant can hand the conversation to the merchant.

A customer does not need a full product catalogue

They need the right response, the right product facts, and a trustworthy next step.



Grounded, not guessed

Catalogue answers should use the merchant’s saved product details.

Clarify before acting

The assistant asks a follow-up question when useful details are missing.

Confirmation is not payment

This pilot does not create orders or process payments. A merchant handles the next step.

AI proposes. SokoPilot checks. Merchants stay in control.

Muse Wonder and Muse Spark prove robust in adequately guiding the user through determining suitable product & closing the deal

01 **WHATSAPP** Customer messages the merchant via whatsapp

02 **SOKOPILOT ROUTER** STOP/START • handoff • rules • AI

03 **AI ASSISTANT** Multi-turn context + tool request

04 **SCOPED TOOLS** Catalogue search, payment link generation, …

SERVER-SIDE GUARANTEES

- **Ownership** — Merchant and customer scope checked.
- **Catalogue facts** — Product details come from the merchant catalogue.
- **Webhook deduplication** — Repeated provider events are deduplicated.
- **Human takeover** — Pauses AI and auto-reply until resumed.

Model never sets price, stock or payment truth

Guardrail: merchants can test before going live.

Edit shop-specific instructions, preview replies, and keep a human in control.

BUILT-IN GUARDRAILS

01	CUSTOMIZE	Edit shop-specific instructions
02	PREVIEW	Test before activation
03	GROUND FACTS	Lookup before product claims
04	HAND OFF	Hand off to a person
05	RESUME	Merchant resumes when ready

MERCHANT SETTINGS

Editable shop instructions

Preview before activation

HUMAN IN CONTROL

Handoff pauses automation; a merchant can resume it from the conversation.

PAYMENT BOUNDARY

No order or payment tools are enabled.

Preview configuration before activation; catalogue facts stay merchant-owned.

Three core layers, shown in the demo app

Built for WhatsApp commerce: Meta model calls, catalogue guardrails, and human control.

META MODEL API

AI

Prompt preview + assistant runs, Chat comprehension integration

CATALOGUE GUARDRAILS

- **Catalogue search tool**
- **Lookup before product claims**
- **Order/payment tools off**

MERCHANT CONTROL

- **Inbox + visible status**
- **Takeover + human reply**
- **Resume assistant**

AND THREE OPPORTUNITIES THIS APPROACH EXPLOITS

WhatsApp Cloud API

Hosted directly on Meta's servers, allowing use at scale

Facebook SDK

In-app creation/integration of merchant’s whatsapp number

Mature payment services

Mobile money and online link payments allow for app integrations

Set up shop your online shop and start selling in 180 seconds.

01	00:00–00:20	Frame the merchant problem and Kenya channel evidence.
02	00:20–00:55	Edit shop instructions and run preview before activation.
03	00:55–01:40	Ask about a product; show the Meta reply grounded in catalogue data.
04	01:40–02:15	Ask for a person; show handoff, merchant takeover, and resume.
05	02:15–02:45	Trace the Meta API call, catalogue tool, and conversation status.
06	02:45–03:00	live checkout or M-Pesa payment.

WHY NOW? The ecosystem is ripe

[1] KENYA DIGITAL CONTEXT

DataReportal, Digital 2025: Kenya. 27.4 million internet users; 48.0% internet penetration, January 2025.

datareportal.com/reports/digital-2025-kenya

[2] META'S MESSAGING + AI DIRECTION

Meta, "Centralized Campaigns, AI Support and More for Businesses on WhatsApp" (July 2025). Meta said it was exploring product recommendations, website sales facilitation and follow-up in WhatsApp. This is Meta's roadmap signal, not proof of Kenyan demand.

about.fb.com/news/2025/07/centralized-campaigns-ai-support-businesses-whatsapp/

[3] WHATSAPP IN KENYA

Media Council of Kenya, State of the Media 2025: WhatsApp (19.8%) led Facebook (18.2%) among platforms named for social/digital information use. This is channel context, not commerce reach or conversion evidence.

mediacouncil.or.ke/media-center/digital-shift-now-reality-kenya-rise-social-platforms-and-audience-power

[4] PRODUCT READINESS

For the video, show the actual Meta Model API preview response and a real test-phone delivery. Seeded database conversations are synthetic; no staging reliability or merchant impact is claimed.

This pilot supports catalogue conversations and merchant handoff. It does not create orders, send real payment links, or process M-Pesa payments.

Sources: DataReportal 2025; Media Council of Kenya 2025; Meta 2025. Figures describe survey/context, not commerce outcomes.

Merchant Dashboard

Paste current app screenshots here after loading the synthetic conversation fixtures.

PASTE CONVERSATION LIST
Show open, closed and handoff states

PASTE OPEN CONVERSATION
Show the catalogue clarification transcript

Client interaction via WhatsApp

Capture a real, consented test exchange separately from the seeded dashboard examples.

PASTE CUSTOMER PHONE SCREENSHOT
Use the dummy client device

PASTE ASSISTANT PHONE SCREENSHOT
Show the actual reply received